

Eta Centauri
895 Suns

Epsilon Centauri
1,815 Suns

Hadar
7,170 Suns

CENTAURUS

THE CENTAUR

A PROMINENT SOUTHERN CONSTELLATION THAT CONTAINS THE CLOSEST STAR TO THE SUN, AS WELL AS THE BRIGHTEST GLOBULAR CLUSTER VISIBLE FROM EARTH.

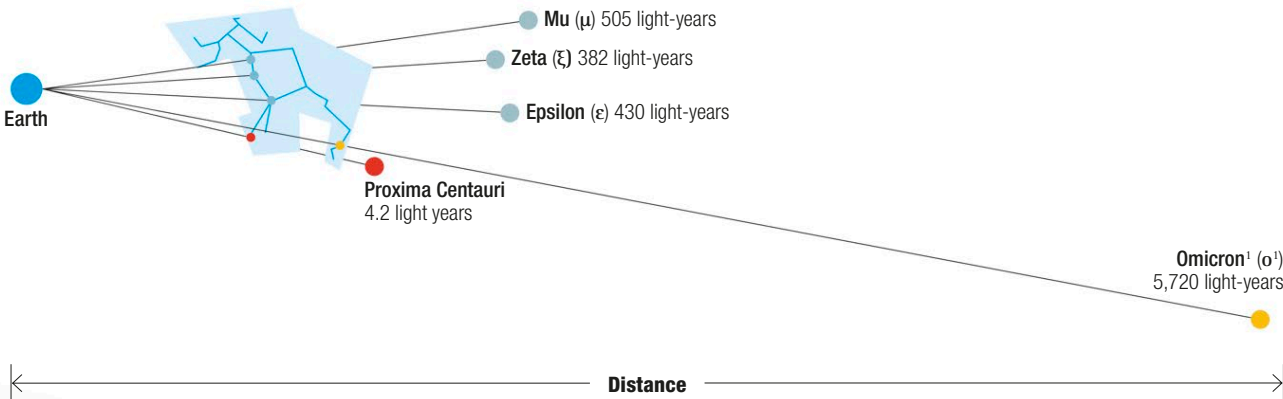
NGC 3918
Planetary nebula visible through small telescopes as a rounded blue disk, hence its popular name: Blue Planetary Nebula

Centaurus is one of the 48 constellations known to the ancient Greeks. It represents Chiron, a wise centaur who taught the gods and mythical heroes of ancient Greece in his cave on Mount Pelion.

Rigel Kentaurus (Alpha Centauri) appears to the naked eye as the third-brightest star in the sky, outshone only by Sirius and Canopus. A telescope splits it into a pair of golden-yellow stars that form a true binary, orbiting each other every 80 years. It is the closest star to the Sun visible to the naked eye. But there is also a third member of the system, only visible with a telescope—a red dwarf called Proxima Centauri, over one-tenth of a light-year closer to the Sun than the other two, making it the closest star of all. In the heart of the constellation lies NGC 5139 (Omega Centauri), a globular cluster so bright that it was at first catalogued as a star. NGC 5128 (Centaurus A) to its north is thought to be the result of a merger between an elliptical and a spiral galaxy.

▽ **Star distances**

Centaurus contains the closest star to the Sun, Proxima Centauri, at a distance of only 4.2 light-years. Epsilon, one of the stars of the greatest magnitude in the constellation, is 100 times farther away, and Omicron¹, the most distant star, is almost 1,400 times farther away.



KEY DATA

Size ranking 9
Brightest stars Rigel
Centaurus (α) -0.1, Hadar (β) 0.6
Genitive Centauri
Abbreviation Cen
Highest in sky at 10pm
April–June
Fully visible 25°N–90°S



MAIN STARS

Rigel Kentaurus Alpha (α) Centauri
Pair of yellow and orange main-sequence stars
-0.28 ↔ 4.4 light-years
Hadar Beta (β) Centauri
Blue-white giant
0.6 ↔ 390 light-years
Gamma (γ) Centauri
Blue-white subgiant
2.2 ↔ 130 light-years
Epsilon (ε) Centauri
Blue-white giant
2.3 ↔ 430 light-years
Eta (η) Centauri
Blue-white main-sequence star
2.3 ↔ 305 light-years
Theta (θ) Centauri
Orange giant
2.1 ↔ 59 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 5139 (Omega Centauri)
Globular cluster
Boomerang Nebula
Planetary nebula
NGC 3766
Open cluster
NGC 3918 (Blue Planetary Nebula)
Planetary nebula
NGC 5128 (Centaurus A)
Peculiar galaxy and radio source